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Leader's Strengths Interview Project

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Section 1

1.1. To complete this project, I first had to figure out the three people I wanted to interview. I ended up choosing three people who know me extremely well but have also seen me in different areas and stages of my life so each interview would be unique in itself. I chose my mom Leigh Anne, my sister Lydia, and one of my best friends Ella. My main goal was to have a mix of perspectives and I was able to do that by not only choosing from both family and from friends but by also choosing someone who I have worked with very closely in more of a team setting.

After I selected my three people, it was time to interview them. With each of them, I explained the assignment in depth and then asked them to think about a specific time when I was at my best as a leader. I gave them the prompt ahead of time so they were able to gather their thoughts and did not feel pressured on the spot. Looking back, I am glad I did that because it allowed for the process to be sped up but still efficient. They were able to come into the interview not only mentally prepared but with an idea already in their head.

During these conversations, I listened carefully and took notes on what they said so I made sure I did not miss anything. I also had the chance to ask follow up questions to better understand why they viewed those moments as my strongest leadership examples. I liked that I was able to do that because some of the responses actually surprised me and I learned more about myself! After completing all three interviews, I gave myself some time to think about each response and really

let it sink in. I tried to relive those times and remember how I felt, I asked myself, how did these interactions make me feel? Did I even realize in the moment? Finally, I connected their observations to leadership concepts from the textbook and reflected on my own experiences.

1.2. Mom, Leigh Anne:

My mom described a time during my senior year of high school when I was balancing school, sports, and helping out at home more than usual. For some context, my brother is four years older than me and played football in college. So when I was a senior in high school he was a junior in college and he would have a game almost every weekend that fall. My parents would go to all of his games and that would leave me alone to take care of my dog and the house for a lot of weekends of my senior year. I had a lot on my plate so I was never really able to get to any of his games that year. With that being said, my mom talked about how well I handled not only being home alone weekend after weekend but keeping everything together so they could go watch their son live out his dreams. She focused on how I remained very responsible and calm, even when things got stressful. There were definitely times and weekends where I didn't think I could manage everything by myself and I was overwhelmed, but I always did and I did it for them. She mentioned that I would help keep things organized at home and how every time they came back the house would be spotless. She saw this as leadership because I was not only handling my own responsibilities but also others all while supporting them and being positive without being asked or even when I didn't want to.

Sister, Lydia:

My sister talked about how I have grown into someone not only she can rely on, but other people as well. For context, my sister is two years older than me so for her, this has definitely been a long time coming. I have naturally relied on her for everything all of my life so hearing that I

have finally grown into someone she can rely on was really full circle. She gave an example of a time when I saw she was struggling and took initiative, stepped in and helped her when things were difficult. Long story short, my sister is being a maid of honor this summer for one of her best college friends. As exciting as it is, the process has been extremely hard for her. The bride has been extremely nitpicky about every single thing my sister has done and what has come across as extremely ungrateful. Obviously hearing all of this I was not happy and felt for my sister, not to mention, she is planning all of this during her last semester of college. With that being said, she was describing a time when I stepped in and was able to give advice, be there for her emotionally, and help solve some problems in a productive way. She said that I lead by being extremely dependable and someone people can trust with anything, which is what makes others feel comfortable coming to me. She viewed this as leadership because it showed maturity and reliability.

Friend, Ella:

As expected, Ella focused on our senior year of high school when we were both captains of our lacrosse team. She described a time when the team was struggling and morale was low. We started our senior season 0-6, which was anything far from easy. There were plenty of doubts, frustrations and ultimate anger to go around. But, instead of letting this get to everyone's head, I decided I needed to bring the team together to remind everyone why we are here and that those games don't define us. I continued to stay positive, instill belief in my team and include every single person on our roster. I led by example but was also there for people when and if they needed it. Ella actually said "you just had a way about it, the way you spoke you could tell that every single person in that room believed what you were saying and their trust was reinstalled. After that meeting, we ended up winning the rest of our regular season games that season and our

belief as a team never wavered again. She saw this as leadership because I helped improve the team environment and performance all while staying calm, positive and leading by example.

1.3. One personal leadership experience that stands out to me was actually one that happened very recently to me on the lacrosse field. During one of our regular season big ten games this year we had the opportunity to play the number one team in the country, Maryland. We were all really excited going into the game and ready to put up a fight. Unfortunately, that dream faded pretty quickly. After the first quarter was over we were down 9-2. Anything less than ideal.

With the score being what it was our coaches decided to make a defensive change from a man to man defense to a zone defense. For context, when we play a zone defense, I get put on the field. With that being said, we made a pretty big overall change and a personnel change that can be tough to adjust to in game. But when I went on the field I huddled up with my defense and talked to them. I told them if we just focus on one play at a time and don't dwell on anything in the past, we will be successful. That's it. Similar to my other lacrosse story I instilled confidence in my teammates and told them if we get scored on its a next play mentality. Turns out we only let in 5 more goals for the rest of the game, I'd say that was pretty successful.

Section 2

2.1. In the examples provided, specifically from my interviews, I primarily demonstrated a democratic leadership style, with some moments of authoritarian leadership. Democratic leadership is a leadership style "in which leaders treat followers as fully capable of doing work on their own and work with followers, trying hard to treat everyone fairly, without putting themselves above followers" (Northouse, p. 360). On the other hand, authoritarian leadership is a

leadership style “in which leaders perceive followers as needing direction and need to control followers and what they do” (Northouse, p. 359).

To start off, I don't think that the example from my mom does fit perfectly into any specific leadership style described in the textbook because I was not directly leading a group of people. Instead, I think it shows more self leadership and responsibility. I took ownership of my responsibilities, stayed calm, and followed through even when I was overwhelmed. I think this connects more to leadership behavior than leadership style. Even though this situation did not involve leading a group directly, I still think it reflects leadership through accountability and setting a strong example.

In the example from my sister, I used a democratic style by being supportive and engaging with her during a very stressful situation. I did not try to control the situation or tell her exactly what to do, I just gave her the support to feel comfortable to do it herself. I listened, gave advice, and talked her through all of her options while also being there to give a different perspective.

Northhouse states, “democratic leaders view followers as capable of self-direction, so they provide counsel and support” (Northouse, p. 66). This reflects my ability to respect her situation and perspective while still helping guide her toward a solution while providing support and comfortability.

Lastly, the example from Ella is the most clear use of democratic leadership style when I was a lacrosse captain. When the team was struggling, I brought everyone together, communicated openly, and instilled confidence in the girls on my team. I made sure everyone felt included, valued and heard, which ultimately showed to have helped strengthen our team's long term success. Northhouse states, “the outcomes of democratic leadership are mostly positive”

(Northouse, p. 61). Along with this situation specifically, there were moments where I used aspects of an authoritarian style. Specifically when I needed to be more direct when I delivered a message to the team. In this situation I specifically “perceived followers as needing direction” (Northouse, p. 60). In those moments, I felt that being clear and confident was extremely vital to regain control and direction of the team.

Overall, my leadership across these situations shows a strong democratic style of leadership. At the same time, in one specific situation there required more direct leadership and that is when some authoritarian style of leadership displayed.

2.2. The democratic style was appropriate in most of these situations because the people around me were extremely capable and motivated, they just needed more of an extra boost from me. My teammates and family members did not need strict control by any means, they just needed communication, support, and collaboration. In some cases they just needed someone to really lean in, listen, and provide another perspective. As Northouse states, democratic leaders “listen to followers in supportive ways and assist them in becoming self-directed” (Northouse, p. 61). By using a democratic approach, it helped create stronger relationships and ultimately better overall outcomes. Along with all of this, when I used the authoritarian approach with my lacrosse team, being more direct was necessary in that situation when quick action and clear instruction was needed.

2.3. The main leadership skill set I used across these examples was interpersonal skills, also known as people skills. These include communication, emotional intelligence, and the ability to understand and work well with others. Northouse defines interpersonal skills as, “those abilities

that help a leader work effectively with followers, peers, and higher-ups to accomplish the organization's goals" (Northouse, p. 101).

I think that in each situation described by my interviewees, I focused on supporting others, listening to their perspectives, and helping create a positive environment. In the example from my mom, I showed interpersonal skills by understanding that my parents wanted to support my brother during his football season, so I stepped up at home without making the situation harder for them. Even though I was overwhelmed at times, I stayed calm and handled my responsibilities. When Northouse describes interpersonal skills he connects it with emotional intelligence, he states "emotional intelligence is concerned with a person's ability to understand their own and others' emotions, and then to apply this understanding to life's tasks" (Northouse, p. 103). I think that is a perfect example of what I did.

In the example from my sister, I used interpersonal skills by listening to her when she was stressed about being maid of honor and helping her work through the situation. I gave advice, supported her emotionally, and helped her think through problems in a productive way and was also able to provide a different perspective. In this situation I was able to understand her emotions and proceed from there. Northouse says, "a leader who knows how to read others' emotions is better equipped to respond appropriately to these people's wants and needs" (Northouse, p. 104).

Finally, in the example from Ella, I used interpersonal skills as a lacrosse captain when our team started the season 0-6. I communicated with my teammates, encouraged them, and helped rebuild trust and confidence. I made sure everyone felt included and I knew that everything I said was important to each and every person on that team. When Northouse talks about "being socially

perceptive,” an aspect of interpersonal skills, he states “it includes having insight into and awareness of what is important to others” (Northouse, p.102).

Overall, these examples show that my leadership often comes from being dependable, emotionally aware, and my ability to connect with others. Everything that interpersonal skills represent.

2.4. My actions align with interpersonal skills because in each example I was focused on understanding what other people needed and responded in a productive and helpful way. I was not just completing tasks or giving advice without thinking. I was really taking into account and understanding the emotions, stress, and needs of the people around me.

With my mom’s example, I aligned with interpersonal skills by recognizing that my parents needed support while they were traveling for my brother’s football games. Instead of adding stress to the situation, I stayed calm and managed my responsibilities at home. With my sister, I aligned with this skill set by listening to her frustration, understanding why she felt overwhelmed, and helped her work through the situation in a positive way. With Ella and my lacrosse team, I aligned with interpersonal skills by recognizing the team’s low morale and responding with encouragement, communication, and positivity that reached every individual player.

In all three examples, I tried to understand the people around me first, and then act in a way that made the situation better. Overall, my actions show interpersonal skills because I was able to use emotional awareness, empathy, communication, and support to help others. Northouse states, “empathy is the critical component of emotional intelligence” (Northouse, p. 106).

Section 3:

3.1 Model the Way

To “Model the Way, leaders must articulate their values and once articulated, their deeds must match their words” (Pergola, p. S58). “Model the Way” means to “Do what you say you’ll do” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*). In other words, it means that leaders set an example through their own actions, simply put, leading by example. Leaders are supposed to show others what matters by acting consistently and wholeheartedly with their own values (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

One way I demonstrated this was in the example my mom shared. During my senior year, when my parents were traveling every weekend for my brother’s football games, I naturally had to take on more responsibility at home. I took care of the dog, kept the house organized, and managed my schoolwork, all while handling my own busy high school schedule. Even though there were definitely times where I got overwhelmed, I followed through and never bailed for myself or my parents. I used this specific practice by setting the standard through my actions, showing my family that I could be trusted to handle responsibilities even when no one was there watching me. I was dependable and did what needed to be done without being constantly reminded. Lastly, I was not leading by giving speeches or telling people what to do, but I was leading strictly through my actions. I was “doing what I said I would do” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

3.2 Inspire a Shared Vision

“Inspire a Shared Vision” means to “see and share exciting possibilities for the future” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*). In other words, helping others believe in a common goal and reminding them of what is possible and inspiring other people to come with you. Leaders do this by creating hope, direction, and belief in the future, all while painting the “big picture” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

I demonstrated this in the example Ella shared about our senior lacrosse season. We started the season pretty rough, 0-6, and to be expected, the team was frustrated and quickly losing confidence in the future of our program. Instead of letting everyone stay negative and dwell on all the bad, I brought the team together and reminded them that those losses did not define us, and that I know what we are capable of and we are not even scratching the surface of our full potential. I helped the team believe that we could still turn the season around if we stayed together and trusted each other every step of the way. Ella said that when I spoke, people believed what I was saying, and that trust came back into the team. After that, we won the rest of our regular season games. This shows this specific practice because I helped the team see a better future and believe we could still reach it.

3.3 Challenge the Process

“Challenging the Process is something leaders must do to move the organization forward” (Pergola, p. S58). “Challenge the Process” means to “empower others to take initiative and experiment” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*). In other words, looking for ways to improve instead of accepting that things have to stay the same. Leaders challenge the process when they take initiative, face problems honestly, and learn from

their mistakes. Challenging the process is all about creating new ways to approach work (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

I think I also demonstrated this during the same lacrosse situation. Starting 0-6 could have easily made everyone give up or blame each other. Instead, I recognized that something needed to change. I challenged the negative mindset the team had fallen into and helped shift the focus from frustration to improvement and belief. I did not accept that our season was already over. I encouraged the team to change our attitude, reset our goals, and keep competing day after day, practice after practice. This was a behavioral example of leadership because I took action instead of just complaining about the problem and I was not okay with accepting where we were at.

3.4 Enable Others to Act

“Enable Others to Act” is actually one that I really love. It means to “foster collaboration and build up others (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*). In other words, building trust, supporting others, and helping people feel capable of their own contribution. Leaders do this by making others feel included, respected, and ultimately confident (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

I demonstrated this in the example my sister Lydia shared. She was under a lot of stress while serving as maid of honor for her friend’s wedding, especially because she was also finishing her senior year of college. Instead of just listening to her situation and moving on, I stepped in to support her and build her up. I gave advice, helped her think through problems, and was there for her emotionally. I did not take over the situation by any means, but I was able to help her feel less alone and more capable of handling it on her own. This connects to leadership because I built trust and gave support in a way that helped someone else keep going.

3.5 Encourage the Heart

“Encourage the Heart” means to “celebrate others by showing gratitude” (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*). Melissa B. Pergola states, “encouraging the Heart creates a spirit of community” (Pergola, p. S58). In other words, recognizing others, supporting them during hard moments, and helping them stay motivated. This practice is about showing people that their effort matters and that they ultimately matter (The Leadership Challenge, *The Five Practices of Exemplary Leadership*).

I think I demonstrated this both with my sister and with my lacrosse team. With my sister, as said previously, I encouraged her when she felt unappreciated and overwhelmed. I reminded her that she was doing her best and helped her feel supported. With my team, I encouraged my teammates when vibes were low and helped rebuild their confidence in themselves and the team. I made sure people felt included and reminded them that they still mattered to the team, even after the rough start we endured. This shows leadership because I helped others feel valued and motivated when they needed it most.

References

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